Share Our Wealth

Sen. Huey P. Long (D-LA) · national radio address · February 23, 1934 · excerpts

Source: Huey P. Long, 'Share Our Wealth' national radio address (Feb. 23, 1934), Congressional Record text via hueylong.com. Public domain.

Louisiana's flamboyant senator launched the Share Our Wealth Society from a radio studio in 1934 with the slogan 'Every Man a King.' Long proposed capping personal wealth at $5 million, guaranteeing every family a $5,000 'household estate,' and providing pensions, free college, and a 30-hour work week. By 1935 the society claimed 7.5 million members in 27,000 local clubs. Long was assassinated in September 1935 before he could mount a planned 1936 third-party challenge to FDR — but the pressure from his movement pushed FDR's 'Second New Deal' (Social Security, the Wagner Act, the Wealth Tax Act).

Connect: The Second New Deal (1935: Social Security, Wagner Act, Wealth Tax) was partly a response to pressure from Huey Long and others. Show how left-wing pressure moved FDR leftward.

Key Passages

The diagnosis

> We have in America today more wealth, more goods, more food, more clothing, more houses than we have ever had. We have everything in abundance here. We have the farm problem, my friends, because we have too much cotton, because we have too much wheat, and have too much corn, and too much potatoes.

'Every man a king'

> Now, we have organized a society, and we call it "Share Our Wealth Society," a society with the motto "Every Man a King." Every man a king, so there would be no such thing as a man or woman who did not have the necessities of life, who would not be dependent upon the whims and caprices and ipsi dixit of the financial barons for a living. What do we propose by this society? We propose to limit the wealth of big men in the country.

On the alphabet agencies

> You cannot solve these things through these various and sundry alphabetical codes. You can have the N. R. A. and P. W. A. and C. W. A. and the U. U. G. and G. I. N. and any other kind of dad-gummed lettered code. You can wait until doomsday and see 25 more alphabets, but that is not going to solve this proposition.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The Great Depression; many Americans felt FDR's early New Deal had not done enough for the poor, as inequality and unemployment remained high.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Ordinary, struggling Americans listening on radio nationwide, especially the poor and working class who might join Share Our Wealth clubs.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Huey Long, a populist Louisiana senator and political rival of FDR, who used radical promises to build national support.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. DBQ Complexity (1 pt): Argue both how Long PUSHED the New Deal leftward AND how he competed with FDR for the same voters.
2. Identify TWO specific New Deal measures of 1935 that responded to pressure from Long and other left critics.
3. Was Long a populist, a demagogue, or both? Defend your answer.